

Round/ed?

A Quora question I was following that sought to find out the differences between today's kids and 90s kids is what prompted this column.

It's fashionable to put down all childhood experiences other than your own and find fault with every other generation in the attempt to proclaim your own generation as the "golden age". Our parents did it, their parents did it...in fact, I have no doubt that as soon as basic language was invented, the adults were lecturing the kids about how they had to hunt woolly mammoths with their bare hands for food and clothing, and how teens were spoilt now with all this newfangled technology – sticks and spears and the like.

I know all the usual arguments about how today's kids are only fascinated by things that have a screen, "They don't read, they only watch videos", etc. Then there are the health implications such as obesity and lack of exercise that people point out. All very valid arguments I suppose, but it's not like we've given them a choice.

If kids like screens, it's because screens are fun and are all around them. It's probably because mum and dad are always staring at their own screens (phones, tablets, laptops, etc) all the time that a child feels the desire to stare at one too.

While we're sitting about reminiscing about how great our own childhood was, we're ignoring the fact that our kids are reading much, much more than we ever did. Yes, a lot of that is social updates or research for school work, but a lot more nonetheless. They're also smarter (with Google; without is debateable) and know a heck of a lot more about a heck of a lot more. As for being outdoorsy, if we choose to live in increasingly congested cities, how can we expect our kids to ever want to go out?

Yes, health and obesity are concerns, but barring technology from kids' lives may not be the answer. It's a struggle to try and keep your kids well rounded these days, and it's also a myth that it's only the kids who need to find the balance. Most of us are the office-bound, staring-at-screens types. We spend a lot more time on our backsides than any generation before us, and that's a trend that will continue. Even the diseases that plague us today are those borne out of laziness – diabetes, heart problems, stroke, etc.

What I'm trying to say is that, yes kids today might be the laziest generation until now, but that's only because we definitely are the laziest adult generation there's ever been. If you really want to bring up your kids (or younger siblings) right, you're going to have to start with yourself first. Switch off, unplug and go low tech every now and then (see Page 46 for ideas). Sit under a tree and read a book (or this magazine) and play cricket with your kids, instead of Candy Crush!

The problem with tech is that it's so damn addictive. There's so much technology-enabled culture opening up to us that it's not hard to see why kids would rather watch swimming bloopers on YouTube than go out and learn how to swim themselves. I use that example because I also never learnt to swim – as a kid, I'd rather read a book or play football, and now I can claim to "never have time". Though I certainly seem to have time for Facebook, YouTube and other things that involve a screen...

So what's the way forward?

I know some people who don't even own a TV (on purpose) and always have family time without screens of any sort (phones or tablets). Their kids seem to be a little more physically active than most (they can actually swim!) However, they also seem a little lost for words when around other kids at, say, a birthday party discussing their favourite TV shows. So, the outdoorsy kids can't communicate with the geeky ones and the geeks are scared of the football the outdoorsy kids are kicking about...Nerds vs. jocks all over again? Except this time, the nerds vastly outnumber the jocks, and the tables have turned not just in terms of numbers – it's also cooler to be geeky and technology savvy now.

I'm no psychiatrist, but I don't think feeling alienated from others is the right way for a kid to be brought up – so that rules out the banning of technology at home. The only answer is to encourage both, screens and outdoor scenes, or else humanity will end up more round than well-rounded – and it starts with us adults of today and isn't something we can sit back and blame on "the kids these days". 



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